

The Girl Who Ran Into My Heart

Chapter 1

The Girl Who Runs Like the Wind

I wasn't supposed to be watching her.

Truthfully, I shouldn't have even been over there. Class wrapped up at two-fifteen on Thursdays, and I needed to hit the library right after, like I always did. Femi had beat me there; said he'd save me a spot, which really meant he'd nap with his textbook sprawled open.

But I didn't go that way.

Who knows why? Maybe it was the sound, feet hitting the track, that constant rhythm, suggesting someone dedicated to this routine. Maybe it was the gorgeous, heavy sunlight pouring over the field.

I halted.

Gazed.

That's when I spotted her.

She ran with such intensity, like she blamed the very ground for existing.

That's the best way I can put it. She wasn't mad in an upset kind of way, but you'd think so looking at her. No, she was determined, like the track was her voice, and she needed it to be heard. Man, could she run! The guys in my class who liked to think they were speedy? They'd be left in her dust in no time. She was going full throttle too; this wasn't a casual stroll around the track.

Her school clothes sat neatly on the bench, while she wore just a basic vest and shorts for racing. With her hair tied super tight, there was nothing holding her back. She zoomed around the track's bend, leaning into it with her entire body moving in sync. Watching her, I got this strange feeling, that maybe I shouldn't be staring, like witnessing some secret.

I ended up hanging around way past when I oughta have left.

When she finished, she slowly came to a stop, leaning on her knees. After standing up straight, she grabbed a towel and wiped her face. She then looked around, but didn't glance my way, I doubt she saw me.

I hurried off after that.

Femi wasn't sleeping when I arrived at the library; he was actually sitting upright, which startled me. But the real shock was how he instantly recognized something was wrong just by looking at me.

"Why do I look so weird?" I asked.

"More like why do you look like you're in pain but aren't sure yet?" he replied.

"Nothing happened," I assured him.

"Tunde, be serious," Femi said.

"There really was nothing to worry about," I insisted.

He gave me that intense stare again, the kind only Femi could pull off, like he's calculating something in his head, then just shrugged and returned to reading his book. I tried opening mine, but simultaneous equations weren't my focus.

They couldn't be with the sight of her. The way she ran, the way she leaned into the curve, and how she dabbed her face with a towel afterward, stuck with me. I barely caught her face, but everything else felt lodged in my chest, refusing to budge.

Tossing a random equation onto the page to act like I was working, I hoped it'd ease my distracted mind.

$$2x + 3y = 12.$$

Staring back at me, it mocked how off-track I actually was.

Then, "Her name is Sarah," popped out of nowhere.

My head shot up so quickly my book teetered on the edge. Femi smirked that infuriating smirk; the one showing he'd won whatever unspoken battle we shared.

"What?" I sputtered.

Like I needed him to clarify, he pointed towards the field. "The girl you were staring at."

Blushing, I argued, "I wasn't" though we both knew I was beat.

"He saw you standing there like a statue," Emeka said, leaning back in his chair and looking super pleased with himself. "When he passed by and waved, you didn't respond. You were just standing there."

I wanted the floor to swallow me up.

"I wasn't staring," I insisted, though I wasn't convinced myself. "I only paused for a bit."

"For how long?"

"Femi"

"How long, Tunde?"

There was no point in replying.

He chuckled softly, that type of laughter that makes whatever he's thinking feel extra mean.

"Sarah Adebola is her name. She's in SS2B. She's the fastest chick in school, maybe even in the entire local government if I want to be honest. Since JSS1, she's won every race." He handled his pen like this was casual info. "Oh, and in case you hadn't checked, she's got looks too."

Trying to argue back left me speechless.

Femi sized me up. "Don't sweat it. Just noticing a girl. Normal."

"I'm totally fine," I argued, even as he showed me the page filled with the same math problem scribbled multiple times.

"You've written $2x + 3y = 12$ four times on that page," he pointed out.

Conceding defeat, I shut the book.

I laid in bed that night, staring up at the ceiling. The fan dragged itself around slowly, just as it did during generator hours after NEPA messed with the power. From the kitchen, I could hear my mom. My sister argued loudly on the phone, as usual for a Thursday night.

My head wasn't on simultaneous equations that night. Instead, I was lost in thoughts about running, seeing someone do it with such intent. Not the usual school gym or sports day running, nor the runners on TV.

It felt different, watching her. She was just doing her thing, not knowing I was looking. People tend to be more genuine when they think no one's watching.

Honestly, I hadn't even gotten a good look at her face. From my spot, she was just far away figures moving through the park.

I knew she was quick, and that she meant business. So when I hit school tomorrow, it'd be impossible not to remember that SS2B was right next door.

But that wouldn't be an issue. Because I wasn't planning on doing anything about it. Sarah Adebola was the fastest runner at our school. And I? Well, I was Tunde, decent at math but otherwise flew under the radar. I definitely didn't just walk up to sports stars and start chatting.

It's fine, I tried convincing myself. Just someone passing by really fast. Move on.

I shut my eyes tight, then imagined seeing her lean into that curve once more.

When I looked around again, the ceiling fan lazily spun above, and my mom's soft hum filled the air in the kitchen. She was singing some tune from long ago that I couldn't name. Yet deep down, quieter than the whispers of wind before rain, I realized I might not let this fade anytime soon.

I fell asleep eventually.

But before I did, one thought sat in my mind and refused to move.

What does she look like when she smiles?

I didn't know why that question came. I hadn't seen her smile. I hadn't seen her face properly at all.

But somehow that was the thing I was most curious about.

And that, I think, is where everything started.

I finally dozed off too, but not before one thought stuck in my head like glue.

Who knows why, I just kept mulling over what her smile looks like.

Strange thing was, I'd never even seen that.

Still, that became my biggest mystery.

Looking back, that moment marked the beginning of it all.

Chapter 2:

A Face I Cannot Forget

By Friday morning, I tried telling myself I'd forgotten about her, but that wasn't true. As soon as I woke up, my mind went right back to replaying that scene. Her track side, the sunshine, and the way she moved still played so clearly in my head. Before I was even fully aware, before hearing the alarm clock tick or sniffing mom's tea from downstairs, I felt it.

I propped myself up and wiped my eyes, then sighed. "This is ridiculous," I muttered. There was no point knowing her face, because honestly, I didn't. Missing this detail was driving me nuts, just like a never-ending math equation without all the proper pieces.

Finally, I pulled myself together, got dressed, and promised to keep things normal. My first class started off decent enough. The school meeting dragged on, and I simply copied notes from Mr. Adeyemi's writing on the board.

Two answers in English were right today, earning me that special slow nod from Mrs. Okonkwo. That nod means she's more surprised than anything else.

Femi was next to me in class, keeping his usual behavior. He only cracked three jokes instead of seven.

Everything was as normal as it could be.

Then break time hit.

Outside, me, Femi, and Chidi, the quiet kid in class who usually kept to himself, stepped out. Chidi tagged along with us during breaks because we didn't bombard him with questions. He appreciated that.

We grabbed some chin-chin from the lady by the gate and hung out under the shade near the building side.

Femi was next to me in class, acting pretty much as usual. He only told three jokes rather than his typical seven.

Things were normal, I guess.

But when break time came, everything changed.

Femi, Chidi, the quiet kid who usually kept to himself, and I stepped outside. Chidi joined us because we weren't pushy; we didn't badger him with tons of questions. He liked that.

We bought some chin-chin from the lady at the gate and chilled in the shade by the building.

During our chat, Femi started telling this long story about his uncle's hunt for a lost remote, which somehow became what Femi dubbed a "full-blown search operation." Honestly, I found it amusing, until those giggling girls came walking by, clutching their books. That's when something strange happened.

One of them caught my eye

I recognized her immediately. It was crazy because I'd only seen her briefly the day before, just a quick glance across the room. Yet there was something about her stride, nobody moved like that. It was so distinctive, so graceful, that I knew right away who it was the second she walked by.

Guess what? It was Sarah.

In that instant, she laughed genuinely, eyes sparkling from some joke her friend made. The type of laughter isn't fake or forced; it comes out organically, catching her by surprise.

Notice how tiny details become noticeable, like that small gap between her front teeth. I swear I wasn't checking her out or anything.

When she walked away, no glances in my direction. Then, her whole crew turned the corner, disappearing from sight.

Enter Femi: "so my uncle claims the remote was never in his room, which is totally bogus because, hey, I saw it myself" I cut in.

He caught me staring at the spot where Sarah had been.

“You zoned out there,” he said.

“I didn’t,” I tried to play it off.

“What did he say?”

I stumbled. “That he lost the remote.”

Femi grinned and glanced back at the corner where the girls disappeared. “Don’t,” I warned.

“I didn’t say anything,” he shrugged.

“I know you’re thinking it.”

“I’m constantly thinking, Tunde. I’m a really thoughtful person.” He took a bite of his chin-chin. “Was that her?”

I stayed silent.

“It was, wasn’t it?” Now he wasn’t even trying to ask. “Sarah Adebola.”

Chidi, who’d kept eating quietly, looked up. “Sarah from 2B?”

“Yeah,” Femi responded.

Chidi nodded slowly, like this answered everything, then went back to his chin-chin.

I turned my gaze towards both of them. “Do we have to make this a big deal?”

“Nobody’s making it a deal,” Femi said. “You’re the one reacting like you saw someone who changed your entire view of the world.”

“I’m standing normally.”

“Tunde, your chin-chin’s been in your hand for three whole minutes, and you haven’t even taken a bite.”

I looked down. He had a point.

I took a bite of the chin-chin.

The rest of the afternoon was awful in its own quiet way.

Nothing huge occurred. The issue was that nothing much happened at all, but I almost bumped into her countless times.

When I rounded the corridor by the noticeboard, there she was with a friend, reading something from the board.

I whipped around before she could glance up and chose the longer path to class. That put me forty seconds late, and I had to justify my tardiness to Mr. Fashola. He took my explanation but made me stand for the first five minutes as a reminder not to be late.

By day's end, when leaving our classes, we emerged at the same time. The corridor was broad, though, meaning our simultaneous exit didn't signify anything special. Plus, she wasn't looking in my direction; she chatted with a girl, gesturing wildly about something. I kept moving at the exact pace I had been and told myself everything was fine. It was fine, I was fine.

As we hit the school gate, Femi caught up.

"So," he began.

"Not happening," I interrupted.

"I haven't even gotten to my point yet."

"No, thanks. I don't want to hear whatever you're planning on saying."

Femi stayed cool, walking right beside me with his hands in his pockets. Unbothered, he matched my stride as we exited the school. There, we merged onto the road where the typical post-school commotion awaited, kids buzzing around, buses idling, vendors pushing their carts.

"She's just a person," I said after a pause.

"Obviously."

I admitted, "I don't know anything about her."

"True enough."

I continued, "I only saw her running yesterday."

Femi, ever helpful, pointed out, "And I spotted you watching her laugh today."

I glanced at him. He shrugged.

"The gap in her teeth is cute," he explained. "But I'm only repeating what you were checking out."

"I didn't"

I paused, then started walking again. "I swear, I hardly looked."

"Tunde, I believe you," Femi said calmly.

His doubt was clear in his tone.

Silence fell between us as we kept walking. A crowded bus zipped by noisily. Some kids from another school kicked a bottle down the street.

"It doesn't matter though," I finally stated. "She hasn't noticed me at all."

Femi thought about it before saying, "Most people only realize others exist when they do."

This wasn't like Femi, so I stared at him. Surprised at himself, he immediately backtracked.

"Don't get philosophical on me," he laughed. "Some movie said it."

That made me chuckle despite my seriousness.

We reached the spot where our paths divided, he went left, I went right. As he walked away, he waved without looking back.

"See you tomorrow," he called out.

"See you," I replied.

I chose the roundabout route home. There wasn't really a reason. I just didn't want to enter the house just yet, with its quiet, familiar sounds engulfing me. You get those moments after school when you're not quite ready to switch from being with others to being alone.

This area was calmer. One lady sold peanuts from a tray, an elderly man read a paper at a tiny store, and two kids played a noisy game with made-up rules.

His words kept spinning in my head.

Most folks don't exist until you meet them.

Clear enough, but it hit me in a weird way. She didn't know me this time yesterday. Today, it was the same; just another kid who had watched her run through a field. Yet, now here I was obsessed with every second of that moment from the day before.

But then, that laugh! The way her head tilted, and that small gap between her teeth.

I wanted to know her.

Not in some grand, film-like scene where someone declares a mission to pursue a person. Just figuring out who she was, you know? Why she laughed like that, why she ran the track down so swiftly, as if showing it her attitude.

The rest of the walk was filled with thoughts of her.

Trying not to think about her was hard, super hard. Yet, that's exactly what I attempted throughout the rest of the journey home.

Chapter 3:

Everywhere I Look

The thing about noticing someone for the first time is that you can't undo it.

Sarah Adebola was just another name to me before Thursday, something familiar like hearing a name at school, connected to random announcements at assemblies, stuff we half listen to and totally forget by lunchtime. She was around, but more like a background character in a story than someone real.

After that, everything changed. Suddenly, Sarah was everywhere, though it wasn't like she was stalking me or anything. My brain just locked onto her like that, how she moved, how she carried herself, even the specific way she tied her hair back. So anytime I glimpsed her, even fleetingly, through a window or across the yard, I was immediately there with her.

Totally annoying, right?

Then Monday happened, which only made things worse. At morning assembly, the entire school was out in the compound during some uncertain weather, deciding whether it was going to rain or shine. That's when it really began to get to me.

The principal was addressing us about exam behavior, basically reminding students not to bring outside stuff that could lead to cheating, though he didn't say it outright. Cheating, you know, we all knew what he meant.

I joined the SS3 lineup, spacing out between wondering if I'd actually filed my assignment or if I'd just intended to. That's when I spotted her.

There she was, three rows up and two over in the SS2 group. Standing there, looking attentive but obviously deep in thoughts of her own. A friend next to her whispered something, and Sarah made an attempt not to grin. It looked like the joke was good because the struggle to contain her smile was clear.

From where I stood, this little moment seemed to squeeze my heart in a totally needless way.

I glanced away, grateful Femi seemed oblivious; he hadn't even noticed our exchange, likely. So, I pretended to listen as the principal droned on about keeping test halls quiet and making sure everyone had their answer books handy.

I nodded seriously, acting like the information really mattered.

Third period, Physics with Mr. Bello, sent me to the office for the marking scheme his forgetfulness left on his desk. Just a quick two-minute task.

Heading back down the hall with the papers, I spotted a classroom door open ahead. Out walked a bunch of kids from SS2B, looking like they were headed for a practical session, notebooks and rulers in hand.

Right in the middle was her.

I kept up my normal pace, steady steps like anyone else rushing to the next spot.

She was engaged in conversation with one of her classmates about some diagram, pointing it out in her notebook. Not a glance in my direction.

Our eyes definitely didn't meet.

As we passed each other, she didn't bat an eyelash.

Back in class, I handed the papers to Mr. Bello and slid into my seat. Femi focused on a problem in his book, never once glancing up. I reached for my notebook too.

The number on my page was 3.8 times ten to some power, and I stared at it for a whole minute, totally lost, until physics brought it all back.

Lunch sucked though.

Our school's dining area was a big echo chamber, always buzzing with chatter and whatever smell the day's lunch was giving off. Long wooden tables lined up in rows, and Mondays meant rice again. Me and Femi and Chidi sat together; he was going on about how our team would've

won the tournament if not for that ref's call in the second half. This wasn't new, he'd been rehashing this since March, and probably would until next March.

And then I looked up randomly and there she was, four tables away.

Watching Sarah with her friends, they seemed totally normal, just like everyone else. Her buddy was going on dramatically about something and she leaned forward on one elbow, chiming in now and then. Her input made the group react in a big way. Not because she was a loudmouth though. It was more that when she talked, she had an effortless confidence. The table actually angled towards her, and they all fell in line with her conversational pace.

I couldn't help but stare but didn't want them to notice, so I pretended to study my meal. Femi whispered, still eating, "You're staring again." I said I wasn't, defending myself. He called me out on looking in their direction specifically. I cut in, "I'm not staring!" Femi gave me that calm look, "Okay, Tunde. Whatever you say. Just know I'm observing."

Chidi eyed us carefully, trying to read between the lines like usual. I told him not to worry; it was nothing. He nodded slowly and went back to his rice.

Femi said nothing more on the topic.

But when I glanced up, just once and for a second, totally by accident, she was laughing at something else. It was the genuine laugh I spotted on Friday during break. Nervously, I stared at my tray and attacked the rest of my rice.

After class, I stuck around to drop off some books in the library.

It was pretty empty, most kids had gone home, and those still there were off practicing or waiting by the bus stop. I returned the books, got one for my assignment, and as I headed for the exit, I heard someone coming.

I moved out of the way for them.

It was her.

Femi whispered a quick "sorry," like folks say when they almost run into you in a doorway, then headed to the window shelf. With a tiny notebook clutched under her arm, she was scouring the shelf intently, like someone who knows exactly what book they want.

She looked so absorbed, I nearly forgot how to breathe.

I stood by the door.

Leaving made sense. Still, I stayed, book in hand, lingering near the entrance in a library was bound to draw odd looks.

I hung around for about four more seconds.

She located her book, took it off the shelf, glanced at the cover, looking content. Then she turned around, and their eyes locked for a split second. The connection wasn't meaningful; she scanned the space like it was a familiar picture, the door, a shelf, a random chair.

Yet this brief moment allowed me a proper, close-up look at her face. Not that previous occasions were clear, the distance in the fields or in the corridors only blurred things. But now? Just a few feet apart, bathed in the gentle light of the library.

Her face was calm, not blank but collected. The sort of face that ponders before reacting. Her steady, slightly weary eyes reminded me of athletes mid-season, and a thin line of concentration marred her forehead. Even though she found what she sought, she didn't fully relax.

She seemed deep in thought.

This woman had a story.

As she exited the library past me, stepping aside wasn't a problem, but once she was gone, I couldn't stop thinking about her.

The sky turned orange as I walked home at a slow pace. This was that lingering sunset light when the day is ending slowly. Suya scents mixed with the dusty air while neighborhood sounds kicked into gear, generators humming, kids playing, muffled TV tunes through open windows.

Those smells and sounds wrapped around reflections on her apologetic glance. Just a polite flash toward a stranger in a doorway.

But one thing took root in my chest.

A wish that maybe, just maybe, we'd be more than that next time.

Not desperately, and not feeling pressure either. Just honestly. Knowing somehow that you want something, clearly and simply, without any drama.

I had no clue how to go about it. When it would happen, I didn't know. Maybe it never would.

But the desire was definitely there.

And it felt real.

Chapter 4:

The Secret Observer

I need to make something clear.

I wasn't a stalker.

I get it, someone describing my week sounds pretty suspicious. Imagine them saying stuff like, "he keeps seeing her in the hallways, he's watching her eat, he's just standing around in the library entrance," it doesn't sound great. However, there's a huge difference between a person quietly noticing someone they like and someone who's acting creepy. And trust me, I was on the non-creepy side.

Or at least, that's what I tried convincing myself.

Tuesday of that week, reality hit me hard. I didn't start out planning where to appear, but once she showed up, I did sort of react. If she ended up in the courtyard, by the snack shop, or at the end of a hallway, I'd hang back a bit. Or think of reasons to peek in that area. Maybe I'd just stay still a tad too long.

Then, I'd catch myself and actually feel ashamed, even if I was alone.

This realization came on Tuesday.

By Wednesday, I decided to quit.

Wednesday only lasted around forty minutes though.

During the compound's brief morning break, I was there by the water tap with Femi. We were drinking water, and he was telling me about some complicated deal with a girl in JSS3. She somehow started drama, thanks to gossip.

I got distracted by a noise.

Not her, I want to be clear. It wasn't like I heard her. I actually heard the song playing, remember? Well, more the silence when that song would be on, you know, that specific quiet moment in the day. Before the athletes hit the field in the afternoon, there'd be this stillness.

This time, it reminded me of Thursday evening, the pounding of feet running through the red dirt, and I got lost in that memory.

"Hey, are you listening?" Femi asked.

"Yeah, the girl gossiped," I replied.

He looked annoyed. "I just said that!"

"What is wrong with you?" he added.

"I'm fine," I said.

"You've been spacing out all since Thursday," he noted.

I took another sip of water. "I'm here now."

Femi stared at me for what felt like forever, and then he did this thing where his expression changed, he dropped the teasing act and showed the side that wasn't as obvious, the side that paid attention and was thoughtful.

"Listen," he said, "there's nothing wrong with admitting you like someone."

"Femi"

"I'm keeping the jokes to myself today. I swear. My point is, it happens sometimes. You spot someone, and suddenly your brain can't stop thinking about them. It's nothing to freak out over."

I stayed silent.

But the way I've been carrying on lately? Well, Femi pointed out that looking glum for nearly a week isn't doing me any favors.

I turned to the tap, and there the water dripped, like whoever left it hadn't quite shut it tight enough.

"I don't even talk to this girl," I confessed.

"I know," he replied.

"It just feels weird, liking someone I barely know."

"Exactly," Femi said with a shrug. "And yet."

I fixed the faucet, making sure it clicked closed properly.

"Exactly," I added, nodding in agreement.

Not doing something can backfire; your brain acts up, making you hyper-focused on exactly what you want to avoid thinking about. On Wednesday, I tried telling myself to stop watching where she was and what she did during the day. Yet, my awareness only sharpened. It was like boosting surveillance right as someone warns you there's trouble ahead.

Post-third period, I saw her cross the compound, quick steps, goal-oriented. During lunch in the tuck shop line, she caught my eye again, picking up a meat pie and drink. She paid, got her change, and moved. Most kids fiddle with phones while waiting, not her. She stood there simply, existing in the regular old world.

After school, I noticed her chatting with Mrs. Okafor outside the Bio lab. Mrs. Okafor nodded and pointed in her book, which told me the chat was serious. It looked academic too – the sort a student has when diving into topics beyond the usual class content.

That one stuck with me. It taught me something, she wasn't just an athlete. She was a student who questioned things, hit up teachers after class, and wanted to truly grasp stuff.

Later that day, I ended up doing something I kind of feel silly admitting now. I bugged my sister about this girl.

My sis, Kemi, was in SS1 at the time, two grades below me. She had this thing for picking up rumors and gossip; younger kids have a knack for that kind of stuff.

So here we were in the living room, right after dinner, flipping through books but really staring at the TV. Dad had left it on, and as usual, he beat us to bed.

I kept my eyes glued to the screen, trying to sound totally laid-back. "Hey, do you happen to know a girl named Sarah Adebola?"

Kemi instantly shot me this intense look younger siblings give whenever an older sibling asks about anything remotely juicy. "The one from SS2B?" she asked.

"Think it's her," I replied.

Then came the inevitable, "Why?"

Just curious 'cos someone threw out her name, I added. She gave me that assessing glance, making me squirm for precisely long enough.

"She's the one who smashed the school record in the hundred meters and the two hundred last year," she said. "She's been running since primary school, and her dad was an athlete too, I think." Then she paused. "Sarah's very focused. Not in a rude way, but like she always has something important to do, even if she's just standing still."

I kept my face neutral. "Okay."

"She's also super nice. My friend Bimpe says Sarah helped some confused JSS2 girls find their way on the first day of term and made them feel comfortable."

Kemi tilted her head. "Why are you curious about Sarah?"

"I told you, Kemi. Someone mentioned her name."

"Who would that be?"

"Femi."

"Why would Femi mention Sarah Adebola?"

"I don't know. People gossip, right?"

Kemi studied me for a second more, then gave a little knowing smile and walked away.

I just sat there staring at the TV, thinking about how Sarah didn't make those girls feel dumb.

I thought about the girl who was the fastest in school, breaking records left and right. She came from an athletic family but also stuck around after school to ask teachers questions. Plus, she'd stop to help lost JSS2 students find their way without drawing attention to it. The image I was forming in my mind got more intriguing and complex.

Thursday rolled around. I can't pin down the exact moment I decided to head back to the field. Seems like it wasn't a conscious decision either. All I recall is finishing up my last class, standing in the hallway outside, thinking about the library assignment I needed to tackle. Next thing, I was at the edge of the field.

The afternoon light was just like that of the previous week, this thick, golden glow. There she was, stretching by the starting blocks with one leg extended and leaning forward. She did this stretch with such care, having clearly learned the proper way and understanding its importance. Nearby, a teacher, who I guessed was the athletics coach, given he was an older man with a whistle around his neck, checked something on his clipboard.

I stood at the edge of the compound, half-behind one of the large mango trees that lined that side of the school. Not hiding, exactly. Just, not presenting myself as an audience.

She finished stretching and stood up. The coach muttered something, and she nodded. Next thing, she took her starting position and off she went, running as if time itself wanted to slow down around her.

The second time around, with knowledge of her name and background, watching her became personal. At first, she was just a random stranger killing it on the field. But now? This was Sarah – the one who'd stop whenever a kid looked lost, asking around about them till she found out where they needed to go. I learned she stayed behind post-class to engage her biology teacher in deep discussions, her genuine giggles unmistakable, complete with the tiny space between her front teeth.

Man, was she quick! Easily top notch compared to my fuzzy memories of her performance from Thursday. As the seconds ticked by, the coach checked his watch intently. When she crossed the finish line, he barked something causing her to nod rapidly. Bending forward with her hands on her knees, Sarah panted heavily.

Every ragged breath, each heaving chest movement? Killer. She gave everything out there, no holding back. Yet peering at her from across the field, there was an evident contentment in her posture. Unlike any weariness or regret, it was clear she'd achieved her purpose for running.

I kept staring for a bit longer, soaking in the moment.

I walked towards the library, trying to act like I'd just been hanging out somewhere else.

I wasn't selling it well, not even to me.

As I walked, one thought stuck with me. It stood out among everything else.

I have to figure out how to start a conversation with her.

Not today and maybe not tomorrow, but eventually.

I couldn't let her remain a distant figure.

She was more than just a mystery put together from pieces, a laugh, a quick sprint, a fleeting smile in the evening sitting room, a lone figure in Biology after school.

I knew I needed to find a way, even if I had no clue how yet.

Chapter 5:

Caught Looking

It all happened on a Friday. Nothing dramatic, though, not like the movies where everything slows down and you've got that dramatic soundtrack. It was totally normal, just really embarrassing, and I've replayed it in my head way too many times.

We had Geography in the morning, doubling down on making it a rough start to the day. Our teacher, Mr. Taiwo, moved super slow, he thought whatever was important deserved time. By the second period, I wasn't writing at all, and my notes became random Geography terms, not making any real sense together: erosion, drainage basin, watershed, deposition.

So I glanced up from my notebook.

Out the window next to me, I should've seen blank school wall space, the place right next to the SS2 block, just red dirt and a row of neem trees with no particular shade spot. Typically, nobody walked through that by this class time.

But then, there she was, walking along that exact path.

I was just out for a walk, maybe running an errand. In my hand was a slip of paper resembling those notes teachers give students to deliver to other staffers. My bag was over one shoulder; I kept it on even for this brief stroll. Some folks do that no matter how short their journey is.

Anyhow, I was watching her walk by. Honestly, I wasn't expecting anything specific. I hadn't formed any particular expectation. Really, I was just drifting into daydreams while my gaze locked onto her movements. It's the type of staring that happens almost without thinking, simply because your eyes alight upon something.

At the path's end, she ascended the tiny steps to the following block. Mid-step, she paused. Glancing upward, our eyes met.

She looked directly at the window where I sat. Our gazes locked.

The proper move would've been for me to swiftly break eye contact. You know, the standard accidental-street-glance-away routine folks use daily. Humans navigate those awkward seconds without a hitch. Glance, divert attention, go about your business. Straightforward, right?

But I didn't follow through.

I froze.

I don't know how long it was. It probably only lasted two or three seconds, but when you're caught staring and the person you're looking at notices, time feels different. It drags on forever.

We locked eyes. She looked at me. I looked at her.

In the background, Mr. Taiwo kept going about drainage basins. And I knew Femi was near, maybe fooling around like usual. But none of that mattered. We were stuck somewhere outside of time, even though the rest of the world tried to carry on.

The clock ticked but we stayed frozen until she did something tiny yet huge. She raised her left eyebrow, just a bit. Not angry, not offended, not even amused exactly. It was a mixture of all those things, but mostly she was just acknowledging the moment between us.

Then, she carried on up the stairs and out of sight.

I forced myself to turn back to my notebook. Erosion. Drainage basin. Watershed. Deposition. The words stared back at me, completely irrelevant.

I just sat there for the rest of the lesson, staring, and didn't write another word.

Femi sensed something was off from the start, even before I explained. Having a best friend like him made things complicated. Everyone else was too absorbed in their own stuff to notice much. But not Femi; he seemed to pick up on my vibes about Sarah instantly, ever since what happened the previous Thursday.

At break time, he matched my pace as I left class.

"What's up from Geography?" Femi asked.

"Nothing big," I replied.

"You didn't write for the whole class and stared at your notebook."

"I was deep in thought."

"Really? About Geography?"

I quickened my pace, hoping to avoid his questions.

"Tunde," he urged.

"She spotted me," I admitted.

A pause followed.

"Spotted how?" he cautiously asked.

"Through the window. She was outside, and I was in. We locked eyes, and I couldn't look away quickly enough."

Another pause stretched out.

"Since when do you look at her?" he finally asked.

"Just for a few seconds," I mumbled.

"Did she say anything?"

She wasn't close enough. She just, I stopped mid-step. We found a quieter spot by the main block, away from other students. Facing him, I shared, "She raised her eyebrow at me."

Femi considered this for a second.

"Was it one or both?" he asked.

"Does it make a difference?" I retorted.

"It can," he explained, "depending on what it means."

"It was just one, the left one."

He nodded slowly, analyzing it like some important clue. "Raising one eyebrow isn't bad."

"It doesn't sound great either."

"It's not about good or bad. It shows she noticed you. At least, that's better than being ignored."

"Yeah, I guess," I sighed, "invisible beats strange."

"Just observe the change," he pointed out, starting to walk again. "The question is where this ends up."

"She'll think I'm weird," I noted sadly.

"Or maybe she won't give it a second thought," Femi suggested, shrugging. "Sometimes people aren't as invested as we think they are in these little moments."

I hoped he was right.

The rest of the morning flew by as I was super cautious. Not like I was obviously trying to be sneaky or anything, but cautious because I knew eyes were on me. So, I hung in the center of groups rather than hanging out at the edges. Avoided the SS2 block like it was cursed, and actually tried hard in my classes. Gave Geography and Chemistry the attention they've never gotten before, but still...

By lunch, I was close to convincing myself Femi probably didn't think much about it. Maybe she just glanced, noticed something, shrugged, and moved on. Almost there, but not quite yet.

Then came after-school time. I found myself at my locker, one of those rows of tiny metal lockers near the SS3 block. I was switching books between my bag and the shelf when I heard a bunch of students heading out for the day. They sounded chatty and totally relaxed.

I didn't peek up right away. Was busy digging around for a textbook I'd shoved somewhere and couldn't find.

The group kept going.

The footsteps slowed, then stopped.

I finally located my textbook.

"Hey."

Looking up, I saw her standing slightly away from the group that had walked on without her. Her bag was balanced right on both shoulders, as if the school day was ending. She studied me, her expression confusing me.

My mind raced, yet all thoughts seemed pointless.

"Hi," was all I could think to reply.

For a beat, she stared back.

"You're in SS3A, right?" she asked.

"Yeah, that's right," I affirmed.

"Okay." A nod as if what she saw solidified her thoughts. "I thought you looked familiar."

It puzzled me that she hadn't mentioned the window or accused me of anything. Perhaps it was kindness or honesty; there was no telling.

Just "Yeah," slipped out. It wasn't really a sentence, but what else could I say?

Her lips twitched upward slightly, not a grin, something less defined.

Then came the call of a friend: "Sarah, come on!"

Readjusting her bag strap, she began to walk again.

"See you around," she murmured, without looking back.

And with that, she was gone.

I ended up standing there at my locker for a bit after she walked off.

The hallway emptied, with students dripping out like water from a tub, the school drifting into its post-hour calm. In my grip was a textbook, yet I couldn't recall grabbing it.

"See you around," she'd said.

Three plain words, the everyday kind that float between two folks passing in a hallway with no need for deeper chat.

I slipped the textbook into my backpack, clicked my locker shut, and mused over how her lips had curled. Not a full grin but near enough to stir some unusual beat in my chest that I didn't want to ponder then.

I began my walk toward the exit.

Again those three simple words echoed in my mind, "See you around."

And here's the kicker, she needn't have halted. Her buddies were up ahead; the exit was, too. Truth be told, I was just that guy from earlier, the one who had peeked at her through a window. Yet, she chose to stop.

She faced me.

We exchanged words.

As I neared the school gates and stepped out into the waning day, a grin stretched across my face.

The struggle was real; trying not to beam at all.

I could barely keep from smiling.

Femi was outside the gate. When he saw me, he closed his eyes, as if getting bad news he already knew was coming.

"Something happened," he stated.

"She spoke to me," I replied.

His eyes opened wide.

"What did she say?"

"She said I looked familiar. She just said 'see you around' and walked off."

He was silent for a moment. Then he said, "And?"

There wasn't more to it. So, there wasn't more to say.

He thought it through and gave a decisive nod.

"Tunde," he began, "you're finished."

I wanted to dispute that.

But I couldn't.

That single exchange, just raised eyebrows and brief words in a nearly empty hall—started planting doubts in my head. Somewhere deep down, I feared he might actually be right.

Chapter 6:

Embarrassment

When the problem is with someone speaking to you only once, it becomes an implicit promise for your brain.

A minor promise at best, not a life-changing one. It wasn't a "I will always be there for you" sort of promise. Just a simple one, a very slight rearrangement of the universe that indicated that I was no longer invisible to her anymore.

This made me realize that Monday morning held yet another problem for me.

Initially, the problem was that Sarah did not know about me. While that was awkward, I knew how to handle it; I watched her from afar without feeling any attachment and nothing much happened. However, now that she knew I existed, she spoke to me because I looked at her; she also told me that she would be seeing me again some other time in the future.

But the question was – What was I supposed to do now?

Monday was just like any other Monday; it arrived far too soon and brightly.

I got to school earlier than usual, not intentionally, just coincidentally, since evidently my brain felt the need to wake me before the alarm went off because it had some processing to do that it could no longer put off. I ate my breakfast without tasting it. I assured my mother that I was okay when she asked why I wasn't saying anything. I wasn't anything special in that sense.

Femi was there at the same time that I was, which was odd since he was usually precisely late, and he walked in step with me through the gate with the air of someone who had been thinking too.

"Okay," he said by way of greeting.

“Good morning to you also,” I said.

“I’ve been thinking about the corridor situation.”

“It wasn’t a situation.”

“She came to talk to you, Tunde. Voluntarily. That’s a situation.” He shifted his backpack. “It’s a matter of knowing what you’re going to do next time you see her.”

“Say hello, probably, like a normal person.”

“Like a normal person.” Femi gave the phrase some consideration. “So you’ve got everything sorted out.”

“Yes.”

“Don’t you have even the slightest bit of nerves?”

“I never said that.”

“Mmm.” Silence was somehow more damning than words could be.

Class time came around. We entered our classroom. I sat myself down. It was my intention to act like a perfectly fine individual capable of interacting with other humans without trouble.

I saw her before lunchtime.

I was just exiting from Chemistry class, bag slung over one shoulder, Femi by my side, still hashing out some issue about the reaction we had done in class earlier, when we entered the hallway and there she was.

Not just across the hall, through a window. Just six steps down from me, in fact, on the opposite side of the hallway and walking towards us as she talked to another girl I didn’t know.

Six steps doesn’t sound like much.

But my body got it first.

I slowed down. Not necessarily that I slowed down but I walked much more deliberately, as one does when one consciously realizes that one is walking. I had no idea where to place my hands. I had been holding the strap of my bag with one hand, which seemed strange somehow, so I placed both hands on the strap, which somehow seemed even stranger, so I finally settled for just putting one hand on the strap, leaving the other hanging by my side.

I was aware of Femi talking to me about the chemistry reaction.

Femi raised her head.

Our eyes met.

And Femi smiled.

Not that half-smile from Friday. But a genuine, albeit small, smile. You know, the kind of smile one offers to someone whom one knows. She displayed her gap.

I told my face to send an appropriate response in return.

My face never got the message.

What actually occurred was that, and here I rely on the information given to me by Femi after, my mouth made itself just a little tiny bit open, my eyes, according to Femi, startled, and I emitted some sound which was not a word. It had in it an attempt at hi or hello or maybe hey, but it was unsuccessful in becoming any of those things.

She walked past.

Her friend said something to her, and I heard Sarah say, "That's the one I was telling you about," and then they were past us down the corridor.

Femi quit talking about Chemistry.

And he waited for exactly four seconds.

"Well," he said, "what was that?"

"I said hi."

"Tunde. You didn't say hi."

"Well, I made an approximate hi."

"It was sort of like the noise people make when they get slightly surprised by a door opening." He paused his walk to turn and look at me, an admirable feat under the circumstances. "She smiled at you. A real smile. And you looked as though somebody had flipped off all the lights."

"I wasn't expecting it."

"You knew that you'd see her at some point."

"A difference exists between knowing and experiencing."

Femi nodded, thinking this over. "True," he conceded. "However, Tunde. Words. Please, use actual words."

"I realize that."

"The next time."

"I do, Femi."

"With your mouth. Actually formed words."

"I understand how words form in a mouth."

"In light of the available evidence – "

"Femi!"

He stopped abruptly. We arrived at the entrance to our building. Femi opened the door for me, and we walked in.

"She said something to her friend after we passed," I whispered.

He gazed at me. "What did she say?"

"She mentioned that was the one I told you about."

He stared at me.

I stared at him.

"She told her friend about you," he said slowly.

"That's what she said."

"The window event."

"She told her friend about you." This was how he worked on difficult questions in his classes. Step by step. "So after Friday she went and talked to her friend about that boy who stared at her."

"Yes. Which could be really bad."

"On the other hand," Femi replied thoughtfully, "maybe she told her friend about the boy she met in the hallway. In which case it would be completely harmless."

"I don't think we'll ever know which one it is."

"No. But she smiled at you today. And she doesn't do that normally if she's mad at someone."

That much was true.

And I kept it close to my chest.

Dinner was self-conscious to the max.

I could feel her presence for the whole time I spent in the dining hall. Though not at my table, not even in any proximity to my table, just somewhere else in the dining hall. I didn't turn around once to look her way. It took quite an amount of concentrated effort on my part, leaving me feeling drained from the entire dinner.

Chidi, who had come again, saw that I was behaving weirdly.

"Are you sick?" he asked.

"No."

"You've been staring at your food."

"I like this food."

Chidi stared at the beans that were on my plate, not the greatest thing to be served on a Monday, then stared at me. "You don't seem happy about that."

"I'm alright, Chidi."

He shrugged, and got back to his beans.

Femi ate with a relaxed contentment, as if things were left to unfold naturally and he just waited and watched what happened.

At that point in the day, I was under the cover of one of the mango trees by the edge of the compound waiting for Femi, who had gone back to classes to retrieve something that he kept forgetting somewhere every other Monday, his calculator – to see him come out when I saw steps approaching along the path covered in gravel.

I expected to see Femi coming towards me.

But it was Sarah.

She walked alone this time with her bag slung across both of her shoulders, water bottle in one hand, obviously on her way to the athletic field – except today was not Thursday.

She was going to walk past me.

I had about three seconds to decide whether to say something or look at my phone and act like I didn't see her.

My phone was inside my bag.

She saw me before I could do anything.

She slowed down a little bit. "Hey," she said.

This time, and I have to say this is a source of genuine pride for me, I actually spoke a real word.

"Hey," I replied.

She stopped walking, which I wasn't expecting.

"You're Tunde, right?" she asked.

A few things registered to me at once. One, she knew my name. And it meant one of two things, either she'd heard of me or asked someone about me. Both of these things were equally important. I told myself not to react to that verbally.

"Yeah," I said.

She nodded. "I'm Sarah."

"I know," I answered. Right after I said it, I realized what I had said and how it would be interpreted. Know. As in, like, I had researched her? Yeah, well, if you wanted to get technical about it, I had. "I mean... People know you. From the athletics."

Her eyes shifted. "Oh."

There was an odd pause.

One where you can see awkwardness looming over it, even as it hasn't quite materialized into anything yet.

"I'm training," she told me, pointing to the field.

"Oh yes, I saw that." I stopped. "I mean... the water bottle and the trajectory."

"Observant," she answered, a dry humor in her voice, and it seemed she knew what she meant by that, without having to explain it, and I think it probably meant window, Thursday afternoon.

Heat crept up my neck.

"I should be going now," she told me, "Coach won't like it if I'm late."

"Yes. Right."

She started heading off.

“Pleasure meeting you properly,” she told me, looking over her shoulder once.

I opened my mouth.

Words came out this time. “You too.”

She didn’t turn around, but there was a slight shift in her posture that might have been a smile.

Two minutes later, Femi appeared, his calculator in hand, and found me under the mango tree, wearing an expression that clearly stated he’d been through many different kinds of things recently.

He sat next to me.

“What did I miss?” he asked.

“She knows my name,” I said.

Femi did not say anything.

“She introduced herself,” I said. “She even said that it was a pleasure to officially meet you.”

“Officially,” repeated Femi.

“Yes, she did.”

He turned to the field and then turned to me.

“Tunde,” he said slowly.

“I know.”

“She knows your name.”

“I know, Femi.”

He nodded once, then stood up and offered his hand to pull me up. And although we were friends for years, he had never done it before.

“We have to get out of here,” he said seriously. “Let’s go home.”

We walked towards the gates.

Neither of us said anything for a while.

“Then,” said Femi softly, almost to himself, “she asked about you.”

“You don’t know that.”

“She knows your name, Tunde. Some people told her.” He paused. “Not everyone knows things.”

It seemed to ring in my mind until we arrived home.

She had asked someone.

Or someone told her.

In any case, she knows my name.

And somehow this small piece of information felt like the most important one for the past weeks.

Chapter 7:

Whispers Among Friends

Femi had developed a theory by Wednesday.

It wasn't really that uncommon of a thing; Femi had theories. About football strategies, about how the school generator broke down at least once every three weeks, about what teachers were actually scared of the principal and what teachers really could care less. His theories were sometimes completely wrong, but always very elaborate, and he would share them with the certainty of a researcher, even if the only work he had done involved just thinking really hard about something.

That particular theory revolved around Sarah.

He shared it with me Wednesday morning in between classes, sitting sideways on the bench in our classroom while most of our class was still filing in, during those last ten minutes before Mr. Adeyemi came in to lecture us.

"She wasn't just using your name," he said softly, in the manner people used when they tried not to draw attention to something they definitely intended to get noticed by. "She used it naturally, as if she already knew it well. As in, she referred to you as Tunde, right, confirming if she had gotten the name right?"

"The same deal. The whole point is, names do not pop out of nowhere. They tell her your name in a setting where you are the topic of discussion."

My textbook lay open on my desk, as it always did at this time, but I wasn't reading it. "You make an awful lot from two words."

"You're Tunde," said Femi, raising his index and middle fingers. "Two words. But the right two words in the right order give you clues. Someone in her group has talked about you to her."

"Why should someone in her group talk about me to her?"

"For the simple reason that you were staring at her through the window, then you came up to talk to her in the hallway, and then she told the girl she was with, yes, you overheard what you

said yourself. You remember that?" He opened his textbook, although for show only. "So her friend knew all about you. And her friend may have said your name. Or she may have asked."

"She may have even asked someone else completely," I pointed out. "She could even have just heard your name mentioned by chance."

"Surely," Femi conceded. "Boring, but surely."

I looked at him. "Doesn't change anything."

"It alters the odds."

"What odds?"

He fixed me with a look that assumed this would be obvious to anyone. "Of her at least being just a little bit interested in you."

"I don't"

"Curiosity sparks interest; curiosity sparks all of it," Femi continued as if he'd read from some book of wisdom. "Curiosity sparks falling in love. You can't fall in love without being curious first."

"Not necessarily"

"Good morning, SS3A."

Mr. Adeyemi walked in, and Femi zipped his lips shut and turned around in his seat. I looked down at my textbook in search of where we left off last lesson.

What irked me about Femi's theory, or more accurately, Femi's interpretation of my actions, was that I couldn't get it out of my head.

Not because I took Femi's theory as the truth. No. But the fact remained that I couldn't prove it wrong, and when you couldn't prove a theory wrong, it became something that occupied your thoughts and distracted you from things that were truly important. Like simultaneous equations. Or chemistry. Or my academic work in general.

But instead, I was thinking about probabilities.

Probabilities that she actually meant asking about me in particular.

Probabilities that nice to officially meet you actually meant what it said.

Probabilities that a girl who set records in school, and whose father was an athlete and who helped some lost JSS2 students find their way, that such a girl spent a significant period thinking about a boy she saw looking out of the window.

I gave them a low rating.

Femi would have rated them higher.

The reality could be anywhere between the two, in that grey area where most realities exist.

On Wednesday afternoon, things took a different turn.

It happened in the corridor outside the notice board when I was reading the latest news bulletin put out by the school authorities. It had news about the school participating in a mathematics contest, together with a comment that interested students who wanted to represent the school should write their names in the space provided below. I was reading the bulletin for real, and with interest, as mathematics was my only subject that I felt really at home with.

By the time I realized there were people talking about me, I was already done reading the notice.

"told you he was in SS3."

"Which one?"

After some silence, "The tall one. Looking at the noticeboard."

I did not look around then; my eyes remained glued to the notice and on the exact same sentence for the third time.

"Oh." Another voice.

"He's quite good-looking."

"I agree."

They continued walking down the hall.

I stayed glued to the notice for a few more seconds, not because I was actually reading but because I wanted some time to digest what I'd just heard before I looked round.

I turned around.

The hall was somewhat crowded, with students leaving class towards home. There were several familiar faces among them, and some I did not recognize. But I did not see Sarah there.

However, I recognized one voice.

The second one, the one that went something like oh, he's quite good-looking, was unfamiliar to me.

But the first one –

Yes, the one that had told the other student she was right; yes, I was sure I could identify it.

It belonged to the girl who had accompanied Sarah on Monday.

Which meant

I signed up for the mathematics competition and left before I had a chance to be making all sorts of faces standing right by that board.

I went to find Femi who was sitting by the gate, eating some groundnuts and watching students moving off after their various classes.

I sat beside him.

"She mentioned me to her friend," I said.

He offered me another groundnut without looking at me. "Tell me more."

I did. The two girls speaking about me in the corridor. The 'he's quite alright' comment. The, "see, I told you he was in SS3."

Femi ate three groundnuts during his deliberations.

"So she has mentioned you to her friend, and her friend has started mentioning you to others, which will mean somewhere down that chain there will be people in SS2B who know who you are."

I leaned my elbows onto my knees. "But is that good or bad?"

"That all depends on whether she said anything nice about you to her friend. If she said something good about you then it's good that people know your face, but if she said 'this strange boy keeps staring at me'"

"It's not so good then."

"That's even worse than useless, isn't it?" he said as he finished the groundnuts, folding the wrapper just like he always did. "But then the friend says you're okay-looking."

"She says okay-looking. Not that and anything else."

"Okay-looking isn't nothing."

"It isn't anything major."

Femi stopped for a while, just as students bustled past him through the gate, a junior boy who tried very hard not to cry over something, a couple of teachers leaving and talking.

"What do I think?" he asked.

"You always have an opinion."

"I think it's time you stopped hoping for things to sort themselves out and made something happen. The competition list. You're going to enter?"

"Yeah, I was thinking about it."

"Then go for it. Concentrate on what you're good at. Stop analysing the whole thing to death when all you really need to do is to talk to her."

I stared at him.

"You managed *hey* and *you too* on Monday," he said. "That's progress. In a few more encounters you might manage full sentences."

"You really know how to make people laugh."

"That is because I really mean to be helpful." He got to his feet, stretching. "She is interested in you. The fact is, you are hopelessly besotted with her, and so am I. These things are undeniably true. But interest isn't everlasting; it must either be satisfied or lost."

I stood up as well.

"Then satisfy it," he said.

We walked out of the compound.

Later that evening, when I was doing some homework in the sitting room, Kemi came over and took a seat beside me, the sort of nonchalant manner that signified that she had an important thing to say.

I waited.

"Well," she said.

"Well," I said.

"Have you heard anything from my friend Bimpe today?"

"Every day she tells you something."

"Bimpe told me that her friend Amaka is looking for information about Tunde in SS3." She hesitated before saying, "I believe she's looking for information about his character."

I looked up.

Kemi was looking at me in the same way as someone who had been patient and is now expecting acknowledgement.

"She wasn't asking in a bad way, Bimpe said. She was asking like" Kemi cocked her head sideways in an attempt to find a word. "Like a researcher asking on behalf of somebody else."

The living room was silent except for the hum of the generator outside the window as the night fell upon.

Research on behalf of somebody else.

I pondered over it.

Femi's words rang in my ears. Curiosity does not endure forever; it either fades away or it's answered.

She was curious about me.

Indirectly. Through another person. Gently. In a manner which people usually adopt to gather information without being outright about it.

That implied she was thinking about me.

That implied I was not going insane.

That implied

"You like her," Kemi stated flatly.

No questions.

I glanced at my textbook. "I don't know her."

"You like to."

Kemi got up, seemingly satisfied with that result, and went to her room. As she walked towards the door, she stopped.

"She's a good girl," she said. "From what I've heard." A pause. "Stop being strange about it."

"I haven't been strange about it."

"You've been acting strangely about this since two weeks ago, Tunde. We all live in this same house."

Then she left.

And I sat alone with my textbook, and the sound of the generator running, and the sensation one gets when they have been seen for who they are by those closest to them, and not knowing whether it feels good or bad.

She had been trying to learn more about me.

So I placed down my pen.

And picked it up again.

I wrote: For Mathematics Competition, Tunde Adewale.

There wasn't much to it. No words spoken, no confessions made, nothing like that. Just a name, scribbled on a piece of paper. My own name, on a Wednesday evening, as the generator hummed in the background, while my sister walked around in the house above me.

But it meant something.

And it was how everything began.

Chapter 8:

The Girl's Secret

And here's a surprise!

As I was busily observing, formulating theories, failing to say appropriate words in the corridor and otherwise devoting more mental energies to one individual than to anything else other than exams before, Sarah, in her version of events, was doing her own thing.

I did not know this at the time of the Thursday morning.

It would be discovered by way of the secondary school grapevine – indirect, messy but inevitable process whereby everyone in the entire school compound knows everything about one another even if they don't intend to.

The day began normally.

First assembly, followed by double English, then a free period when, theoretically, one should have been studying independently but, in practice, there were other things going on. People slept, people chatted. Chidi actually read a book, which was consistent with his character. Femi revised for his Chemistry exam on Friday morning using the technique of reading his notes out loud in a very quiet voice.

Same with me, Chemistry, the exam was going on, and unfortunately, I did not feel as prepared for it as I hoped I would be. When suddenly, a girl named Ada who belonged to my class returned from somewhere, sat two seats away from me and started conveying something to her seatmate with her low-fast voice, signaling its urgent nature.

I was not really paying attention to anything else except for what Ada might be trying to convey to her seatmate.

There was a specific kind of silence present in the class during free period, not complete but definitely very low. Voices could travel farther than people expected in such conditions.

"she's been having extra training due to her participation in regional trials," Ada explained.
"The coach added sessions on Tuesday and Thursday morning before we even start school."

"Why?" her seatmate asked.

"To prepare Sarah for it. She has six weeks left until the regional qualifier and if she comes first in the top three she will qualify for state championships."

I kept reading my Chemistry textbook.

"Are you for real? She clocked eleven point eight seconds last month for the one hundred. Best record for this school for the past decade." Ada spoke with the air of someone well versed in the sports field. "It's because of the girl from Government Secondary School; can't remember her name, I think it was Blessing. She ran eleven point six in the previous inter-schools competition. So it's very close."

"Very close."

"Sarah knows that; that's why she always gets here early. She barely takes quick lunch now because she goes to the track. My friend from 2B tells me she saw Sarah crying after training last Tuesday. It was not as if she was sobbing out of sadness, no, just...you know. That crying which happens because you have pushed your limits and everything seems to be overwhelming all at once."

My seatmate responded with a sympathetic tone.

"But she never lets on," Ada said. "She is fine as usual when she attends class. But she sure has a heavy burden."

I turned to the next page of my notes of Chemistry lessons.

I did not read it.

Eleven point eight.

It may have been too long ago for me to recall precisely what that time indicated in the greater context of Nigerian secondary school athletics, but I had an understanding of close enough to know what I knew when I heard it. I had an understanding of what six weeks meant with something vital waiting at the end of it. I had an understanding of what it means to be good at something and to know that isn't always going to be enough.

I recalled what Kemi had said about her: she looks like she has somewhere to go even when she's not moving anywhere.

Now I could appreciate the significance behind it.

That sense of purpose I had perceived in her wasn't all-encompassing; it was precise and finite. There was a limit to it, which lay sixty days ahead. By then, there would be a girl by the name of Blessing who had run eleven point six and whose advantage over her was only two tenths of a second, which in a race was both little and everything.

Her mornings before school. Her crying in private after practice because she believed nobody saw.

This image of hers changed in

Femi listened as he ate systematically, then commented, "You were not meant to hear that discussion."

"I was not trying to listen. It was my free period and the room was silent."

"Yeah." He did not pursue it. "And she is under stress."

"A lot of stress. And apparently, she is not discussing the matter openly. She just keeps it bottled up inside."

Femi was silent for a moment. "That explains a lot."

"Like what?"

"Well, like why she always seems to have something weighing on her mind even when there isn't anything to think about. You mentioned that once or twice. That she has a 'thinking face' even when nothing is really going on."

I had mentioned that before. I just never knew he had remembered.

"Some people internalize everything," Femi explained. "They do not show their emotions; they just keep everything hidden beneath the surface." He ate another mouthful of food. "Such people tend to be more intriguing."

He met my eyes as I stared at him.

"What?" he asked.

"Surprisingly perceptive of yourself?"

"I'm always perceptive, but usually you're busy with someone else."

I ignored it.

On Thursday afternoon, I stayed behind.

It was becoming a habit that I didn't analyze too much. The Thursdays, and athletics field. There was always a reason why. The library, a project, something. Thursday was no exception; this time I was really waiting for Femi who had a discussion with the mathematics teacher regarding the contest. And the truth was, the fact that I was sitting by the low wall, on the side of the compound that had an almost complete view of the track if viewed from a certain position was just mere coincidence.

Almost.

She was already here when I arrived.

But something was different this time.

She wasn't running.

She was standing by the side of the track, arms folded, staring at the ground. The coach was somewhere close but not addressing her, as he continued writing something on his clipboard, and she remained there, wherever she was. Her water bottle was lying next to her feet.

She just stood there for quite some time.

Then she did something I couldn't believe at first sight.

She lifted her head to the heavens.

Not in an exaggerated manner, like something done in a movie when the person needs help or is in a reflective period of their life. A brief glance up to the skies, maybe thinking about the

weather, but the weather was fine and she kept staring up longer than you'd expect her to while just observing the weather. She had an unreadable expression at the distance she was from me but somehow, I could see that she appeared to be reminding herself of something. Something that she needed to see in the skies before moving on.

She glanced back down.

She knelt down, grabbed her bottle of water, took a long sip, and put the bottle down.

She moved into her starting position.

She took off running.

And she was much quicker than I've ever seen her run.

Perhaps it was due to the extra training, or perhaps the six weeks, or even something else she had discovered when looking out at the sky. Regardless, she came away from the starting block with something that seemed to be unlike anything she had done before, something more urgent, as decisions tend to be once they have been thoroughly and carefully made. She rounded the first curve, came down the straightaway, and the head of the coach snapped up from his clipboard, watching and timing her as she ran.

She placed her hands on her knees.

Then she looked up again.

And this time I understood what she was seeing.

It wasn't an expression of happiness or satisfaction. It wasn't an expression of joy or triumph. Instead, it was an expression of someone who is right in the middle of something important and hard that has not yet been completed, and they have made the decision to continue pushing forward regardless.

Determined. Tired. Committed.

And I stayed there, sitting on that wall, and felt a feeling I hadn't anticipated.

Not the normal one, not the noticing, not the special warmth that came about because she was around. Something deeper. Something that was unrelated to the space between her two front teeth, how she always seemed to laugh or whether or not she had ever enquired after me through a mutual friend.

Respect.

It took Femi twenty minutes to find me.

He could tell from my face as he drew near, and so he just sat down beside me without immediately questioning me, and this was an act of kindness.

A while later he asked, "She's good, isn't she?"

"She's very good," I replied.

Together we watched the last few minutes of her training. The trainer called out something, she nodded, and then went through an exercise that I could tell was her cooling down process – calculated and systematic.

"Femi," I said.

"Yes."

"How do you go about speaking to people when you know facts about them that they haven't told you straight?"

He considered it. "What do you mean by that?"

"That I know she's working on the regionals. That I know she's been practicing early in the morning. That I know this is killing her." I saw her place her towel into her gym bag. "None of it came out of her mouth, Femi. I learned this from other people's chatter and from observation. The point being that when I speak to her, there will always be, this kind of gap between me and her. The gap of what I know and what I know that she knows I know."

There was silence for some time.

"Of course you don't have to pretend that you know nothing," Femi replied at last. "However, you shouldn't start off by telling her about all your observations. Just talk to her as another human being. Let her share things that she feels ready to share. You don't bring up things you've heard or seen. You just simply come clean."

"And what if she asks how I noticed?"

"Things just happen when a person takes an interest in someone," Femi answered. "It's perfectly normal."

She picked up her bag and left the field with the coach, the two of them having some discussion. She didn't even turn towards where we were seated.

"She's carrying a lot," I whispered.

"Yes," Femi replied.

"And she's carrying all of that on her own. Or almost on her own."

"Yes."

I continued to watch until she turned the corner at the end of the block.

"I do not want to be just someone who observes her from afar," I said. The words left my mouth without much premeditation, but they rang true and Femi understood how sincere I sounded, because he did not joke or mock me. "I want to know her properly."

Femi did not mock me.

Instead, he only gave me one solemn nod.

"That you will do," he said. "One conversation at a time."

We waited for a few more minutes after that.

The field was bare now, the track silent, the afternoon sun starting to soften as dusk approached.

I recalled a girl who had stared into the sky before running.

And I knew, for the first time, that what I felt for her was not just the intoxication, the vertigo of falling in love for the first time with an object of beauty.

Something else had begun in me that would take longer to articulate.

But it had started.

And it was growing.

Chapter 9:

Curiosity

She smiled at me again that Friday morning.

This time, I was prepared.

Somewhat prepared. Prepared in the sense that I had managed to dedicate part of the previous night thinking about how people normally interacted, telling myself that language was nothing but sound put together in a certain way, and that I had succeeded in making that sound for at least twelve years without ever having a problem.

She smiled at me during assembly.

I was just getting in line with my classmates, the organized chaos of school, teachers watching from the sidelines, all the while feeling rather lost, when I looked sideways.

She was there, in line, relaxed with a bag by her feet, and she was looking my way.

As soon as she caught my gaze, she smiled.

No raising an eyebrow, no hint of a smile from one corner of her mouth. Just an honest smile, swift and simple, the type reserved for those who have moved past stranger status.

And I smiled back.

Properly. Consciously. Using the proper facial muscles.

And she turned her gaze away.

And I turned mine away.

Standing in line at my spot, I felt like I'd somehow survived a small test.

Behind me, Femi let out an almost inaudible "Hm."

And the weekend intervened before anything else took place.

On Saturday, the only purpose seemed to be reminding one that life outside of school existed. I needed to help my mother at the market with shopping bags and haggling for what we had already agreed to buy; it just made us feel better to do it. At home, where my father was this time, the TV showed some sort of football match throughout much of the afternoon, while I sat next to him, watching and not really watching because my mind was somewhere else.

On Sunday, after the mandatory church and a lengthy meal, there came Sunday afternoons again, those moments of peace and nothingness that allowed me either to read or sleep, but I chose neither today.

Kemi stopped by my room twice and on each occasion peered in but did not say anything. She gave me an emphatic shake of the head that was laden with meaning without uttering a single word.

I was no longer being subtle.

Monday dawned.

And with the start of Monday came one thing that had not been expected.

A letter.

It was left in my locker when I opened it on my way to first period. There was a folded sheet of paper, no envelope, wedged against my Chemistry book. It had my name written on it in script writing that was not familiar to me, neat, tilted at an angle, writing of the type where you could tell the writer scribbled with speed.

I glanced around the hallway.

Nothing out of place. Nobody observing me. No one looking for any reaction from me.

I opened up the note.

It stated:

You're competing in the math contest, aren't you? I just saw your name on the list. Best of luck.
S

That was all.

Four sentences and one signature letter.

I reread it three times.

And then I folded it, pocketed it, locked my locker and made my way to class with the carefully neutral face of a person who hadn't just had a minor internal experience.

Femi knew within four minutes.

How he knew, I have no idea. I hadn't said a thing. I'd walked in, sat down, opened my textbook and made an excellent impersonation of a student whose focus was entirely upon academics.

He leaned over and asked me, quite quietly, "What happened."

"Nothing."

"Tunde."

"I'm reading."

"You're holding your book upside down."

I checked. He was right.

I turned the book around.

"There's a note in my locker," I whispered, in my lowest possible voice.

Femi's face changed completely. "Who from?"

"S."

He stared at me. "S as in"

"Yes."

"What did it say?"

I told him.

He stared for a while at the front of the room, where our teacher wasn't yet. This was fortunate, since Femi's face was now performing some rather interesting facial acrobatics and it was hard to explain to a teacher.

"She knows your locker," he murmured.

"She's gotten her information from somewhere."

"She's asked someone." It was spoken definitively. "One doesn't randomly come across another individual's locker number. She's asked."

"She must have noticed it at some point."

"When would she have been able to notice your locker?"

I couldn't answer.

"She asked," Femi repeated firmly. "She has searched out your locker number, she has written you a note, and she has placed it in there before you got to school this morning." He paused. "Tunde. This morning when she woke up on Monday morning, one of the first things she did was place that note in your locker."

As he said it, it began to seem important.

It was.

"It's only good luck wishes," I argued.

"Yes, for the competition. Which means she's seen your name on the list. Which means she's looked at the competition list." He picked up his pen. "Or someone's informed her that you're on the list."

"You're constructing a theory again."

"I'm compiling facts," he countered. "They're two different things."

I considered the note all morning long.

Not obsessively, but somehow I kept my head around Chemistry and English without going totally out of it. But it was always there, lurking in the background, subtle and relentless. The simple matter of fact. That she had written something, that she had signed her name just with an initial, tentative as if afraid to take too much credit, that she had wished me luck for something she had seen on a list.

She was paying attention.

To the very details that I was paying attention to.

It stayed in me like an idea that is slowly being realized.

I saw her during lunchtime.

But not at the opposite end of the dining hall like last time, but truly saw her, face-to-face, since we got to the door practically at the same time coming from opposite directions. She was with her friend Amaka, whom I now recognized to be the girl with the voice from the hallway. I was alone, Femi had gone back for something and I went ahead.

Both of us got to the door together.

I held it open for her.

She glanced first at me, then the door and finally back at me.

"Thanks."

We entered together, not really, only the fact of entering in unison through the same door that one does all the time at school, without significance. Except Amaka was right there next to Sarah, looking at us with considerable interest.

"I read your note," I told her.

The words slipped out much more smoothly than I thought they would.

She looked at me, and there was some slight adjustment in her expression, something in the recognition of her preparations for the fact that perhaps I wouldn't, but that I did.

"I wasn't sure whether it would seem strange."

"It didn't."

"All I could see was your name and then" A little half-shrug. "Well, good luck."

"Thank you," I said. "I'm going to need it. These questions are always out of another dimension."

She almost laughed, and I saw the beginnings of it in her expression, saw it start and be caught again.

"Are you good at maths?" she asked.

"Good enough to participate, not enough to take anything for granted."

It emerged before I had made up my mind about asking. It was a genuine question, not flirtatious, not clever.

She was looking at me the way she had been in the library, seriously.

"Yes," she answered plainly.

Amaka, who was standing next to her, had frozen in the position people tend to adopt when pretending to ignore something.

"Well, good to know," I remarked.

By then we had reached the food queue. Following the natural order of things we were drawn closer together by the line, then pushed apart by it as we progressed to our separate places in the queue.

She got her food and went to her accustomed seat.

I got mine and started looking around for a place to sit.

Before I did sit down I cast one last glance around.

Amaka must have been talking to Sarah because the way that Sarah's face was set suggested she was listening to something that had happened.

Then, Sarah's head lifted.

Our eyes met and I felt myself flush as she locked on to me, her gaze intense.

This time, her face wasn't split down the middle into an expression of bemusement – her face stayed neutral but there was something behind it and within it, some kind of complex thought.

Then, Sarah turned her attention elsewhere.

That day at lunchtime, Femi arrived later than usual and saw me eating with more calm than I had experienced lately.

He took his seat next to me and, after studying my face, remarked, "Something happened."

"I actually spoke to her, like proper," I admitted.

"What's your definition of 'properly'?"

"Well, a few sentences. Whole sentences with actual information. I brought up the note. Had a small discussion. Actually asked her a question and she answered."

Femi put down his tray. "And what did you ask?"

He looked at me.

"And she said yes," I told him.

He kept on looking.

"Femi."

"I was just" He looked away. "Where did that come from?"

"I don't know. It was the truth."

"It was a rather direct way of putting things when you two weeks ago wouldn't even be able to say hello."

"I know." I considered this. "I think I got tired of being careful with every word I said. Every single thing I have ever said to her has been so" I was looking for the exact word. "Monitored. All carefully checked through three filters before being let out. This one slipped by."

"And it worked."

"She seemed to appreciate it."

Femi nodded thoughtfully. He glanced at his food. Then he looked at me, in what was quite rare for him, a non-ironic way. Without any sort of sarcasm.

"This is who you really are," he told me. "The honest and straightforward version. Much better than the cautious one." He paused. "Be that one from now on."

That night I settled down at my desk to do some studying.

I opened up my book on mathematics.

Yes, I prefer honest.

I considered the manner in which she had put it, plain and undecorated, like one declares an established fact regarding oneself.

I considered everything that I knew of her now.

She would run at dawn when the campus was silent. She bore a burden within her that did not surface outwardly. She would inquire about people through mutual acquaintances before meeting them head-on. She would pen her letters to others with her initials appended below for fear of taking credit. She would be honest. She was the kind of person who laughed despite her attempt to restrain it.

And somewhere among all those things, somehow between the girl I once saw sprinting on a Thursday afternoon and the girl who gazed at the heavens before a training class, I had ceased to be a person awed by her afar off.

I was developing into someone who was truly curious.

In the manner that she appeared to be truly curious about me.

Two people asking questions about one another via the only method that they knew prior to being able to ask each other anything else.

And I wondered what would come after this.

It was something that I did not know.

For once, however, I did not fear the question.

This was progress, indeed.

Chapter 10:

The Competition Announcement

The announcement came on a Tuesday.

Not the contest itself, because that had already been announced on the notice board about two weeks earlier. No, the announcement made on a Tuesday morning was one about the groups being made. Who had been chosen to participate. How the preparation would take place. And above all, who would be working with whom.

Mr. Adeyemi made his announcement during our class session, and was then echoed by the same during the short notice assembly session that we held after the break. Our school had decided to send two teams of five students each to the regional math contest, and since the preparation sessions would include mixed groups, which meant mixing SS2 and SS3 students, as per the principal's terminology of 'cross-stream academic collaboration'.

I was included in the group.

I got to know just like how everything else gets known around that school.

Femi saw the bulletin board before me.

He returned to my side where I stood by the water tap, and in the face of a person who handled information rather than letting it burst forth, which he had a tendency to do sometimes, although this information was being held on a special reserve and considered carefully as to whether to be shared in dramatic or normal fashion.

It had been decided that it would be normal.

"You and Sarah are in the same group," he said.

I looked at him.

"Group Two," he said. "A five-student group. You, Sarah, two SS3 kids I know named Biodun and Cynthia, plus another SS2 kid."

There was silence for a while after that.

"Say something," Femi instructed me.

"I am thinking."

"Thinking about what?"

"The fact that for three whole weeks I will be spending time in the same room as her."

"Yeah," Femi confirmed with a nod. "That is the thing."

I went up to the notice board personally after break.

I studied the list thoroughly. As Femi had predicted, Group Two consisted of five names, which were listed randomly, having been typed out and printed on the notice board at the school office.

Hers was the third.

Mine was the first.

The other SS2 student was a person called Tolu, whom I faintly recognized from the science corridor.

I stood before the notice board pondering this information and trying to gauge my response to it. Truthfully, there was more than one thing going through my head, and none of them very pleasant.

There was obviously the thing that was most obvious; the fact that I would have three weeks to spend time with Sarah in the same room as her. No engineered encounters, no accidental meet ups in corridors. Genuine time in the same room with an exact purpose that meant we would talk to each other.

In this context, as someone who was developing romantic feelings toward her, everything would carry more importance than what would have been the case in an average group-study session. I would be doing mathematics, in all seriousness and earnestness, because the competition mattered to me, even while I was fully aware of the person seated opposite me.

And that made things a little different.

I had not moved away from the noticeboard yet when someone joined me.

Even before I turned my head to look, I could recognize the essence of her presence, having developed the skill to discern it through no conscious intent.

She was studying the list.

We were standing together next to the noticeboard amid the post-break shuffle of students, saying nothing to each other for a brief time.

She finally broke the silence. "Group Two."

"Group Two," I confirmed.

She studied the list for a little longer, then turned her head just a bit in my direction. "You actually know mathematics or did you just join up?"

Straightforward. Slightly taunting. And deadpan.

I looked into her eyes. "You actually know mathematics or you're worried your group's going to end up carrying you?"

There was something else in her expression that altered. It wasn't that she was offended; it was almost the reverse. Almost as if she'd posed a pointed question, which got a pointed answer, and both of these were equally fine with her.

"I'm alright," she told me. "At least not your calibre, if you're the one Adeyemi has been talking about."

"He's talked about me?"

"He talked about a student from SS3A who worked out that simultaneous equations assignment without learning the procedure beforehand."

"SS3A?"

"That's what he said – not your name, but SS3A – and the only one from SS3A listed here is you."

I let this information sink in. "He mentioned that?"

"In class. To illustrate that we weren't studying as hard as we could."

"That wasn't what I meant to do."

"I know." She faced me more directly. "I'm not holding it against you. I just wanted you to know that was how I first heard your name."

Before the other things – the window, the hall, the note.

"And then I saw my name up there for the competition?" I asked.

"Yes."

"And I wrote you a note."

Her expression changed. She was more careful now. "I thought it would be a nice thing to do."

"It was."

We stared at each other, while around us, everything in the school moved on, as bells rang and voices sounded and everything else went about its business at the close of break time, but this specific part seemed quiet.

"Monday then," she said.

"Monday," I replied.

She walked off.

I met Femi in our classroom.

He saw me sitting down and got some impression from my face because he sat up.

"What happened at the noticeboard?" he asked.

"She was there."

"And?"

I considered how to condense the story. "She said she heard about me from Adeyemi. That business with the simultaneous equations."

Femi blinked. "She knew about that?"

"I guess he talked about it in their class. That was the first time she heard my name."

"Before the window."

"Yes. The sequence of events: she hears my name from a teacher, sees me at the window, stops in the hall, writes the note." He paused for a second as if to process all that had happened to him. "She's been collecting data on you just like you've been collecting data on her."

"That seems pretty likely."

"Two people gathering intel on one another without realizing the other was doing the same thing."

He shook his head again, this time not with disapproval but with approval. "Tunde. That is, that is something."

"It's a coincidence," I argued.

"It absolutely is not a coincidence," he countered. "Two people are curious about each other, and are therefore acting on that curiosity by engaging in whatever it is people do when they're curious about someone without knowing how to go about acting on their curiosity."

I did not contradict him.

"For three weeks now, Mondays, Wednesdays, Fridays. You will be in the same room as her for an actual reason, and she already knows your name and respects you enough to write you a note." He grabbed his pen again. "This is the best case scenario or the worst case scenario or both."

"Let's not get into the feelings thing," he said. "Let's stick to the math. Be yourself – the self that figures stuff out even before they teach you how. Show her that self." He stopped speaking. "That's all that matters anyway, one way or another. At least you'll be genuine."

I sat in front of my desk that afternoon, at home, and did not study math.

I looked at my notebook.

I considered Monday.

Three weeks. Twelve classes. At least forty-five minutes each, possibly more. Timed interaction, for a reason, so that means we would definitely have to converse, solve problems, experience the unavoidable tension of working in a group.

What she had said. Do you actually understand math or are you only here to get the credit? The cutting edge of her words, and the hint of softness below the edge, the impression that she was gauging me and didn't really dislike doing so.

I thought back to her statement on Adeyemi using me as an example of integrity. It was honest but slightly annoying. She did not have to inform me of it. However, she chose to be consistent to her claim of being a person of integrity by letting me know of it.

I prefer honest.

It was slightly annoying.

Monday then.

Three statements from three completely separate discussions, each saying something to me.

I held my pen.

I turned the pages of my notebook until I found a blank one.

At the top I wrote: Regional Mathematics Competition, Preparation Notes.

Below, in slightly smaller letters, as if I had not even thought it over:

Pay attention. Not only to the math.

I stared at it for a while.

Then I crossed out the latter part.

Not because it was false.

Because not everything had to be written down to be true.

On Friday afternoon, Kemi saw me in the sitting room, poring over some old competition papers printed out from the school's resource folder.

She studied them. She studied me.

"It's six weeks before the competition."

"We will have three weeks of practice classes from Monday."

"Do you normally prepare so early?"

"No."

She thought about that for a moment. "Do you have any specific reason for being so prepared?"

"Kemi."

She perched herself on the sofa's armrest. "Is she in your group?"

"Not a question, more of a statement."

"Group Two," I said.

Her smile emerged unsuppressed. "So now you have your reason."

"I had my reason before; I like mathematics."

"You like mathematics," she said, as if storing the information somewhere for later use. "Okay."

"Kemi."

"I was just saying." She turned to leave. "It's good, having a reason."

She left.

I scanned through the previous years' contest papers.

It's good, having a reason.

Outside, the evening would have been nothing out of the ordinary, with the hum of the generator, sounds of music coming from some place in the streets outside, or the scent of the food being cooked in the kitchen – everything that we experienced regularly in the evenings on a Friday.

The Monday, on the other hand, felt, for the first time ever, like anything but just another start to the week.

Like a door.

Closed.

